

UChicago Summer Farm Strategy Intern

(Avocado, Citrus, Passionfruit)

Location: California (primarily remote with one on-site visit)

Duration: 8-week summer internship

Time Commitment: ~40 hours/week (flexible, to be agreed upon)

Overview

This internship offers a unique opportunity to work directly with the owner of an 80-acre California avocado, citrus, and passionfruit ranch on real-world agricultural strategy, operations, and investment decisions. The intern will tackle broad, open-ended questions facing the ranch and translate data into practical recommendations that guide how time, capital, and resources are deployed.

The role is intentionally broad in scope and designed for a highly motivated, analytical intern who enjoys problem-solving in ambiguous environments. Most work will be done remotely, with weekly check-ins with the ranch owner and one on-site visit to meet the ranch manager, understand day-to-day operations, and collect local data from the ranch, packinghouse, and nearby farmers markets as needed.

Key Responsibilities & Projects

The intern will manage multiple projects over the 8-week period. Core projects include, but are not limited to:

1. Avocado Block Productivity Analysis

- Analyze historical and current avocado production data.
- Develop a clear framework, metrics, and/or tool to evaluate productivity by block.
- Identify high-performing versus underperforming blocks.
- Provide recommendations on where future investment (fertilizer, water, pruning, labor) is warranted and where it may not be economically justified.

2. Citrus Decline & Replanting Strategy

- Analyze areas of declining or dying citrus on the ranch.
- Review prior ranch strategic reports prepared by local agricultural consultants.
- Conduct market analysis of viable crops in the Santa Barbara region.
- Propose future planting or alternative land-use plans for affected areas, integrating agronomic, market, and financial considerations.

3. Passionfruit Sales & Profitability Tool

- Design and build a simple, practical system to track passionfruit sales.
- Analyze revenues, costs, and profitability of the passionfruit crop.
- Identify opportunities to improve margins, pricing, or operational efficiency.

4. Opportunity Identification & Prioritization

- Propose additional analyses or projects that could meaningfully benefit the ranch.
 - Evaluate and prioritize these initiatives based on potential value, effort required, and strategic importance.
 - Consider organic and regenerative options during this analysis.
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Learning Opportunities

The intern will gain hands-on experience in:

- Agricultural strategy and decision-making at the ranch level
 - Data analysis with incomplete or imperfect datasets
 - Creating tools and frameworks to clarify complex operational questions
 - Market and financial analysis in specialty crops
 - Communicating insights and recommendations to a business owner
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Qualifications

Required:

- Strong analytical and problem-solving skills
- Comfort working with ambiguity and open-ended questions
- Ability to gather, clean, and analyze data from multiple sources
- Strong written and verbal communication skills
- Self-directed, organized, and able to manage multiple projects

Preferred:

- Coursework or interest in agriculture, economics, business, environmental studies, data science, or related fields
 - Experience with Excel, Google Sheets, or similar analytical tools (Python/R a plus but not required)
 - Interest in food systems, farming, sustainability, or land management
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Work Structure

- Primarily remote work
 - Weekly check-ins with the ranch owner
 - One on-site visit during the internship to meet the ranch manager, understand operations, and collect local data
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Deliverables

By the end of the internship, the intern will have produced:

- Practical analytical tools and dashboards usable by the ranch going forward
 - Written summaries and recommendations for each major project
 - A prioritized list of future opportunities for the ranch
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Ideal Candidate Profile

This role is well-suited for a student who enjoys combining data, strategy, and real-world impact—and who is excited to see their work directly influence decisions on a working farm.